This continued till the third standard before I let her go home. After fifth standard, I shifted school.

Schooling at Desiya Vinayaka Devasthanam was a breeze, and I topped in the tenth standard. In the pre-university course at South Travancore Hindu College, too, the feat repeated. When my close friend and academic competitor Kaliyampillai chose to study medicine, I thought for a moment and decided that applications of Pythagoras won't help much in treating cholera or removing an appendix. So engineering it was for me.

Just when I was to apply for an engineering seat, I fell ill with typhoid, pneumonia and pleurisy. It was a deadly combination, and my mother was paranoid that something might happen to me. And she had her reason; my eldest sister had died at the age of eighteen. All I was told was that she had a 'bone problem.'

Down for several weeks, I missed the admission that year and joined Scott Christian College, Nagercoil as a BSc Maths student. It was only an interregnum, and I resolved to apply for engineering the following year.

Tamil Nadu had just six engineering colleges then, two government colleges and four in the private sector. The government colleges were in Chennai and Coimbatore. The others were Thyagaraja College of Engineering, Madurai; Alagappa Chettiar College of Technology, Karaikudi; PSG College of Technology, Coimbatore; and College of Engineering & Technology, Coimbatore. Though a year late, my grades in the pre-university course still kept me in good stead.

I chose Thyagarajar College of Engineering, Madurai, a 500-acre hilly campus where peacocks roamed. Thyagaraja Chettiar, the founder, was not an academician, but he made sure that the college had the best of faculty and facilities to produce a bright crop of engineers that the nation badly needed.

I joined the college in June 1960. It was one of the most poignant moments in my life, when I realised the depth of my emotional bond with my father—and vice versa. So far, father had been a figure of respect and fear for me; he rarely interacted with us children. He would leave early for his oil shop and by the time he got back home, we would be fast asleep.